

What does the algorithm miss?

**The current state of user-generated content platforms, participatory culture,
and algorithmic recommendations**

Self-understanding in the form of mere intermediaries (Gillespie 2010) and connectors of the world (Turner 2006)

Recommender systems designed as traps to captivate and accumulate attention (Seaver 2018)

Content moderation and rights enforcement takes an industrial stance (Caplan 2018, Gillespie 2018)

The diagram features a central circle with a light gray interior and a thick dark gray border. Inside the circle, the text "User-generated content platforms" is written in bold. A horizontal line passes through the center of the circle. Five text blocks are arranged around the circle: one at the top, one at the bottom, one to the left, one to the right, and one at the bottom right. Each text block is connected to the central circle by a thin line.

**User-generated
content platforms**

Recommender systems operate as technologies of the self (Karakayali et al. 2017) and create value far more complex than just commercial one (Livingstone 2018)

Datafication and predictive analytics allow for people to be addressed/governed individually and affectively (Clough 2018, Couldry and Mejias 2018)

Operating logic is at the same time liberating and communitarian as it is controlling and restraining (van Dijck and Poell 2013)

Three challenges of studying algorithms (Kitchin 2016)

Access

- Not only hard to get but data will be shaped through technical decisions made while accessing
- Institutional inequality between academia and industry (boyd and Crawford 2012)
- Transparency - knowing comes from seeing - forms ill-fitting metaphor (Ananny and Crawford 2016)

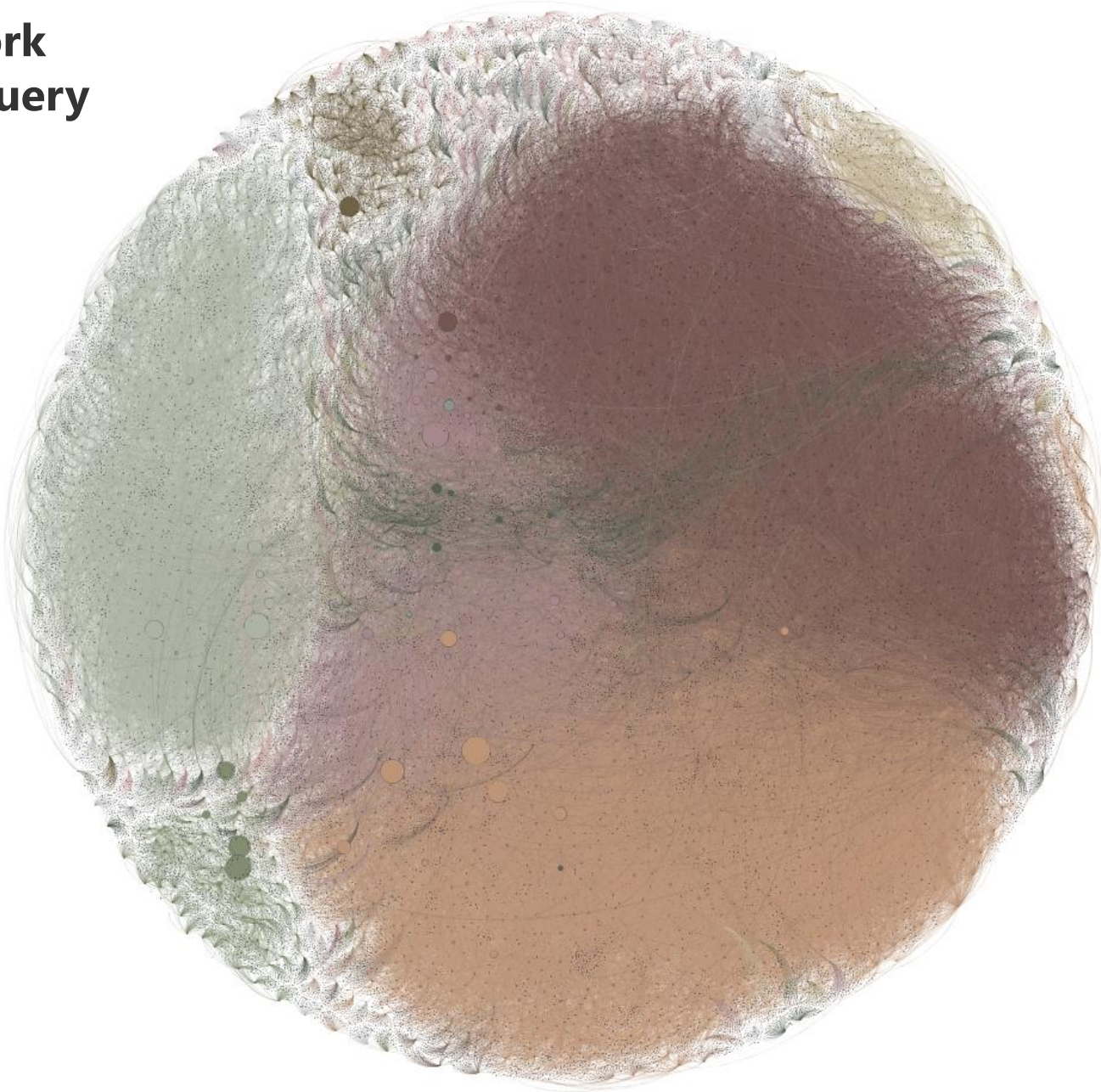
Embeddedness

- Algorithms are part of larger, complex settings of different algorithms, datasets, protocols, standards, laws, and so forth
- Techno-centric inquiry – code with consequences – must be supplemented by a reflection of social constructedness and institutional embeddedness (Gillespie 2014)

Contingency

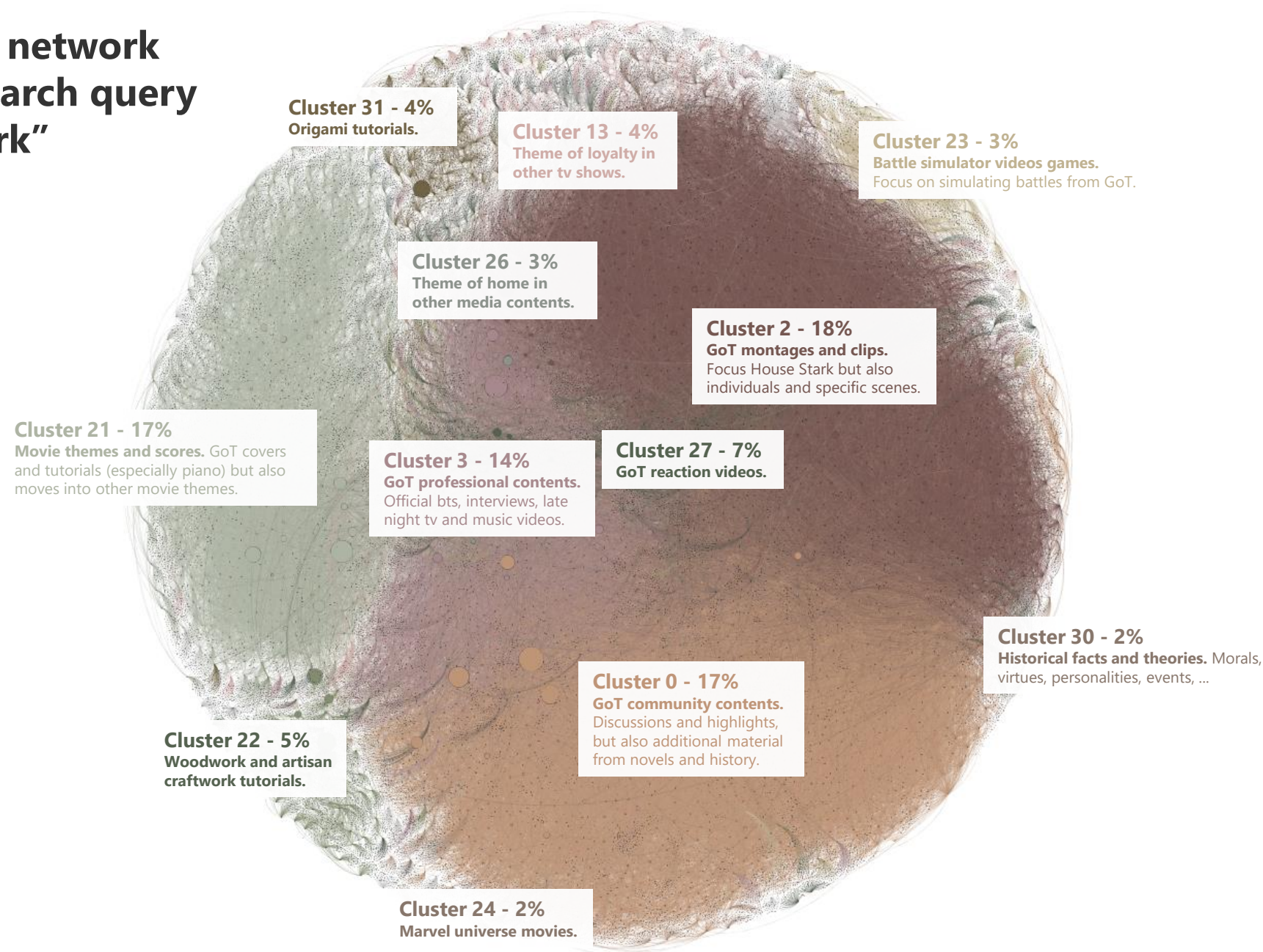
- Algorithms are constantly worked on, unfold and interact in dynamic and recursive ways
- Not only must different approaches be combined but also discrepancies between qualitative and quantitative be bridged (Halford et al. 2014)

**Related videos network
for YouTube search query
“got house stark”**

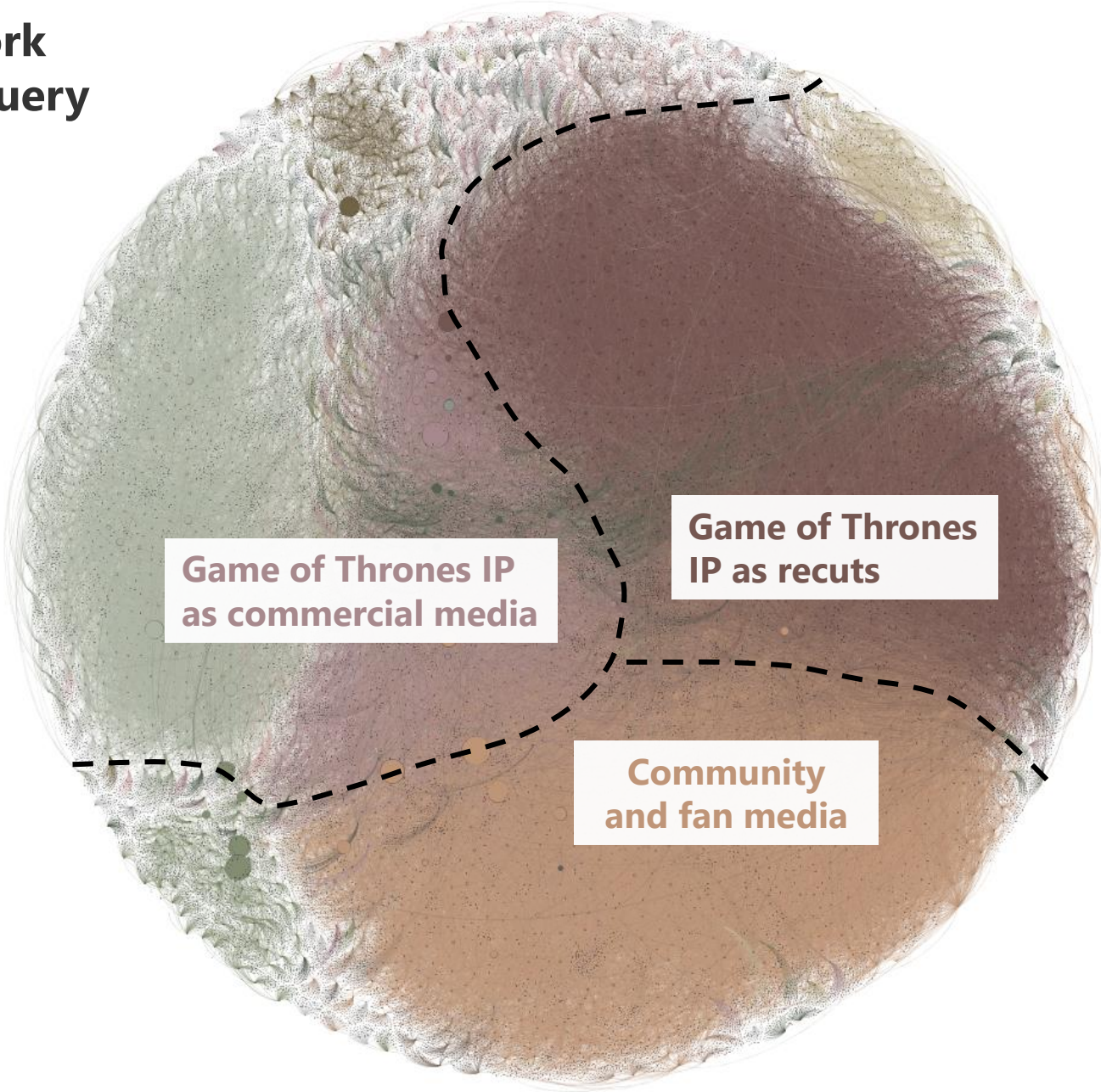


Nodes	36972
Edges	123310
Clustering coefficient	.11
Average degree	6.8
Diameter	17
Range clustering coefficient within clusters	.1 / .15
Clusters / colour by	Louvain Modularity
Node size by	Betweenness
Layout	ForceAtlas2

Related videos network for YouTube search query “got house stark”

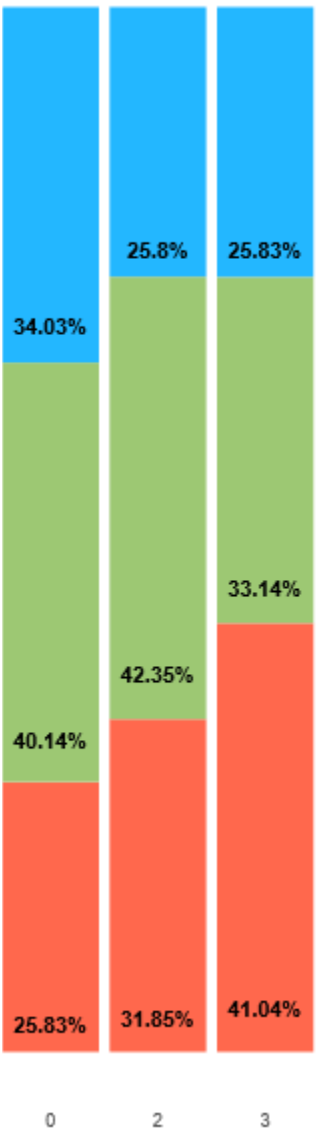
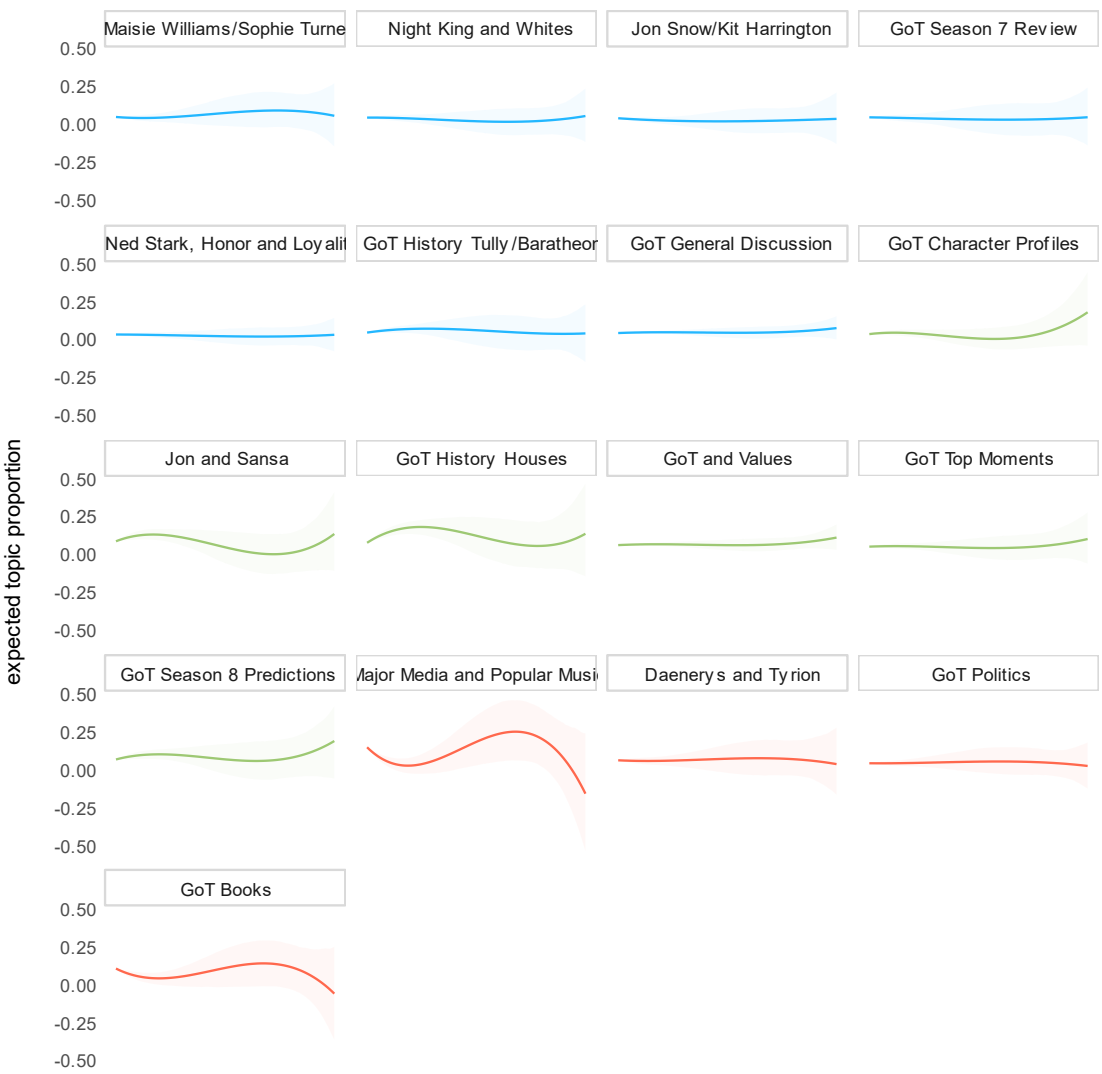


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Effect of betweenness centrality on topic distribution for Clusters 2, 3, and 0



Topics placed **neutral** by the algorithm are general discussion of GoT but also videos featuring the cast and interviews with them.

Topics **pushed** by the algorithm are especially montages of GoT characters and community videos concerning the upcoming seasons.

Topics **slowed down** by the algorithm especially are major media and popular music contents but also videos discussing the GoT books.

However, note that these videos still make up 1/3 and more of the traffic!

Creating such maps **allows us to understand and reconstruct the linked ecologies** which are at and can be **at work in contemporary digital cultures**.

We have to **emphasise the organizational role algorithms play** as entities equipped with agency and affective presences. They observe, classify, and order, are adapted and changed. Hence, only in precisely and concretely mapping what they do (and what they miss) are we to understand the full complexity of value created on digital platforms today.

Thanks!

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